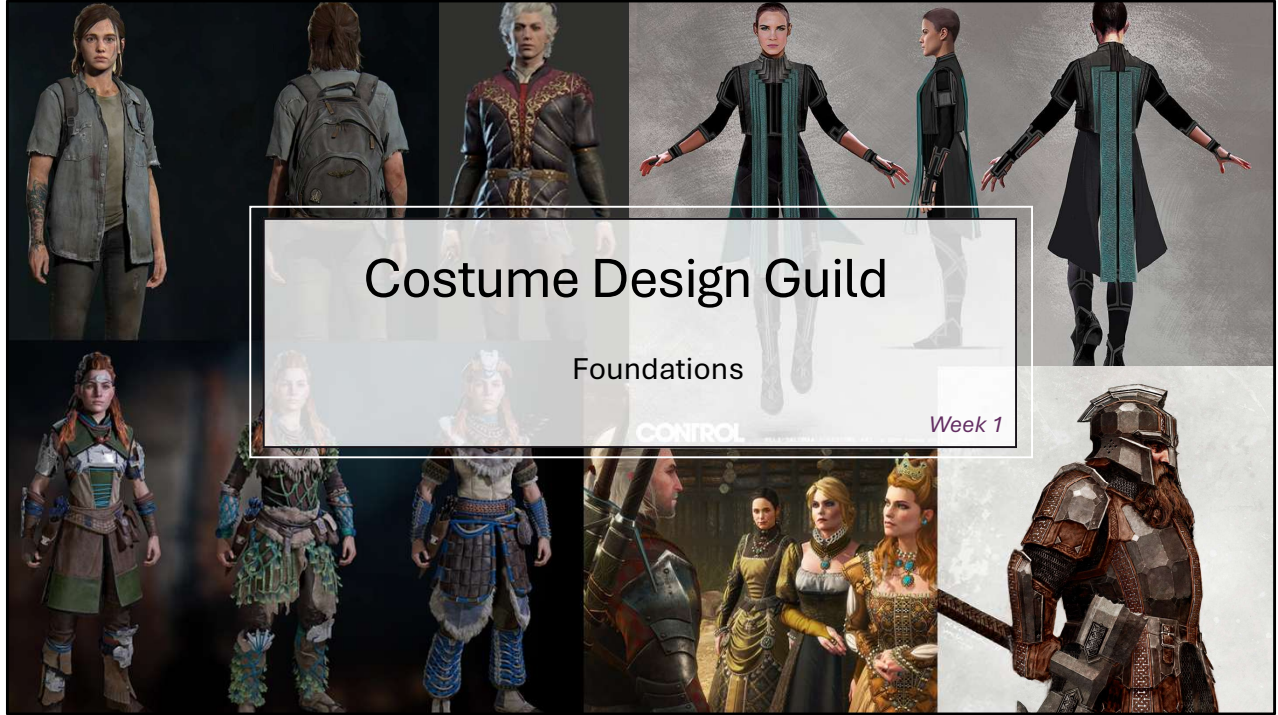




My master research

- I'm a fashion designer interested in video games, now master game technology
- Running these guilds as part of my master research
- Needs to be recorded for documentation
- Your input is my data
- Helps me graduate 😊
- In turn: Ask me for help, feedback etc on your costume work!



To introduce myself quickly, I am Imara, my previous study was fashion design and I am now doing my master in game technologies.

I've started running these guilds as part of my master research, and it's about figuring out which costume design principles are important for video game design, and I will find this out by observing how you guys interact with and react to the guild content I have prepared for you guys

Your input, thoughts, reflections, work you show me if all part of the data I'm gathering. Your input will help me graduate

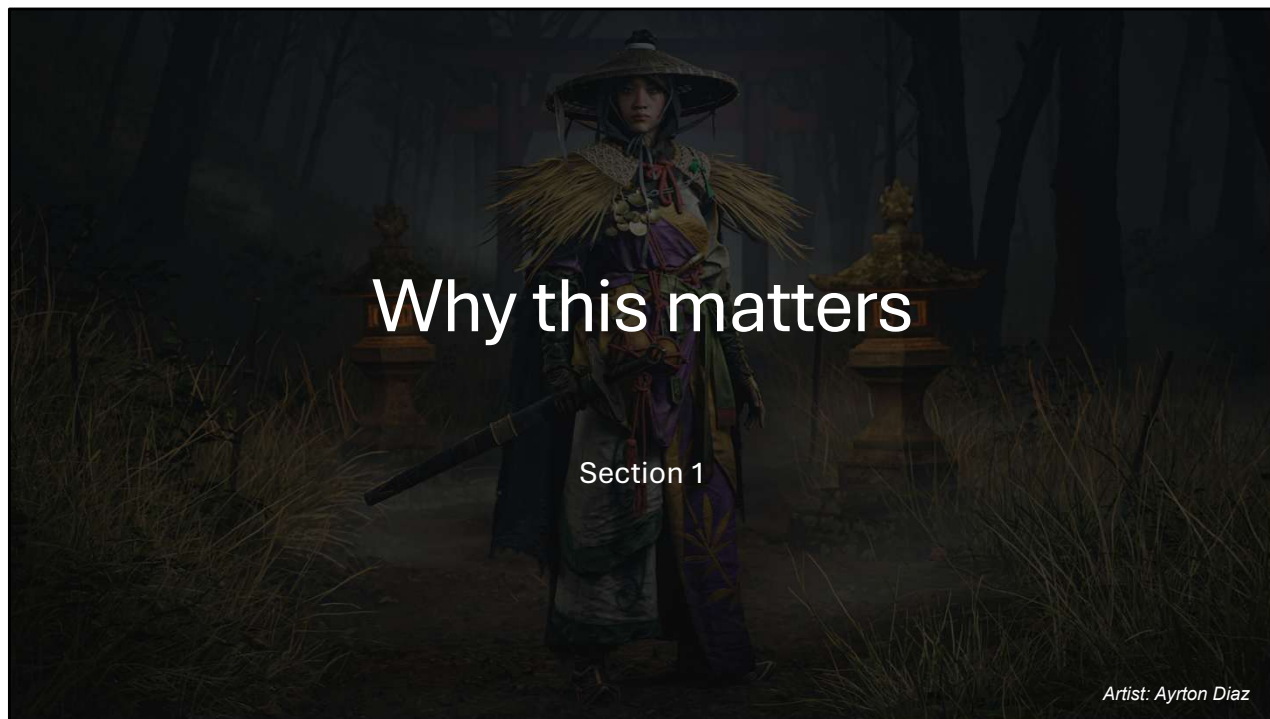
And in turn I am always available if you need help, feedback or anything else.

Agenda

1. Why this matters
2. What you'll learn
3. Foundational concepts
4. Creatures & beings
5. Period mixing
6. Tools
7. Wrap up & discussion



So this is the agenda for this guilds session, it's an introduction to what costume design is for video games specifically with some foundational concepts



So you might ask why this all matters



Let's start with the difference between fashion and costuming in games

Fashion = self-expression, it's trend-driven, and shows designer's vision. As you can see with collabs between designers and games, like fortnite on the left

While Costume = character-driven, has narrative support, and is part of the world-building.

Most Games need COSTUME thinking, not fashion thinking but it's good to be aware of the difference

And this costume thinking can also be called costume literacy

costume literacy

noun | cos·tume lit·er·a·cy | /'kɒstju:m 'lɪtərəsi/

Definition: The ability to read, interpret, and apply the visual language of clothing and dress in character design contexts; understanding how garment construction, historical periods, material properties, and cultural codes communicate character information, social status, and narrative function through costume choices.

Usage: Primarily used in game design, film, theatre, and character art education to describe the foundational knowledge of how clothing functions as a storytelling and world-building tool beyond mere decoration.

Example: "Developing costume literacy enables game artists to make informed design decisions about silhouette, materials, and period-appropriate details without requiring a full costume design degree."

Related terms: visual literacy, design literacy, semiotic reading, dress codes, character costume design

See also: fashion literacy (self-expression focused) vs. costume literacy (character/narrative focused)

So what is costume literacy?

[It's the ability to read, interpret, and apply the visual language of clothing and dress in character design contexts

[Its about how clothing functions as a storytelling and world building tool beyond aesthetics

[It allows you to make informed design decisions without needing a full costume degree

Even stylized games benefit from costume literacy

- Knowledge makes things BELIEVABLE, even when not realistic
- Silhouette, colour, material logic still apply



Ellie from the last of us is a good example of when costume works for high quality games

But costume literacy also has a benefit for stylized games like it takes two

Knowledge makes things BELIEVABLE even when not realistic

Here Silhouette, colour, material logic still apply

The design of may and cody show that the character artists behind them knew how fabric looked close up (see knitted edges), how seams work (may's pants), which makes these stylized characters believable within the story and world



No Mans Sky

- Functional, believable design
- Not just decorative suits



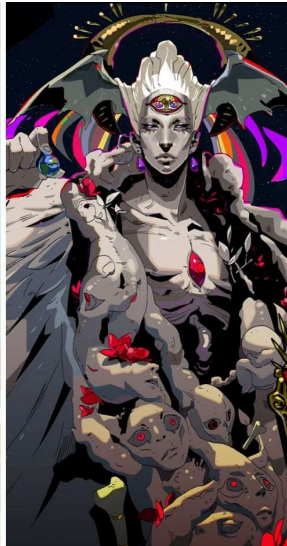
Heres another example of stylized game using costume literacy well
No man's sky had functional and believable space suit designs that are not just decorative. All details have a purpose



Dishonored 1 & 2

- Recognisable design (jobs, wealth, hierarchy)
- Form and function fits character

Another example is dishonored, this game tells characters story through garments, focussing on form and function for the job or place the character has in the story



Hades

- Artistic style but believable
- Character's look is deeply tied to personality and narrative

Hades also does costume design well, even though the style is very artistic. All clothing looks believable and are tied to personality and narrative

Accuracy vs dramatization

- Historical accuracy ≠ always the goal
- Dramatization for NARRATIVE
- Recognizability vs. accuracy



But theres a tradeoff you need to make for designing costumes
Historical accuracy, or construction accuracy isn't always the goal
The players need to "read" character instantly, historical or construction accuracy is then less important

Here an example of the witcher series where geralt twirls and spins in battle, this isn't accurate in terms of historical martial arts rules
But he does this in the game too, where the reason for this is because he's a very strong witcher, his skill allows him to go beyond traditional fighting logic

Accuracy vs dramatization

Example: Viking horned helmets

- Not historically accurate
- Myth started by Wagner's opera (19th century)
- Worldwide adoption

BUT horns are aligned with narrative:

- Barbaric
- Strength
- Adventurous



[Source](#)

Another example is viking horned helmets

This is not historically accurate as Vikings never wore these helmets

This is a good example of a detail that is not historically accurate but aligns with the viking narrative,

It strengthens the story of Vikings who are kind of barbaric, the horns show strength and can be read as adventurous

Costume In Other Media



Film costume considerations:

- Camera focused
- Extreme detail
- Multiple identical pieces
- Cheat elements
- Camera angles to hide details

Let's get into costume in other media

Costume for film is Designed for camera only and needs to be detailed enough for extreme close up shots

Multiple identical garments need to be made, stuntmen, wear and tear, nonlinear filming

Using Cheat elements, sometimes garments are basted together just for a 5 second scene

Costume In Other Media



Theatre costume considerations:

- Distance focused
- Bold shapes
- Quick changes possible
- Durability priority (*many shows a week*)

Costume for theatre is made differently as

Viewers Must read the character from a distance so silhouettes are Exaggerated for visibility

Quick changes possible, so a historically accurate corset would not work for theatre as putting it on can take 20 minutes. So they need to be adapted

Costumes for period plays are often recognisably from that period, but not accurate in terms of construction

What makes game costume unique?

- 360-degree visibility
- Player control
- Interactivity
- Performance constraints
- Modularity
- Extended viewing time
- Reusability



So what makes game costume unique ?

As you all know better than I do, an outfit in a game can be seen from all angles, you can't force the player to only see it from one angle as you do in film or theatre

--Outfits must often be interactive, a cape bouncing when you jump for example and fit within the performance constraints of your game

-- It also often needs to be modular, players can combine garments into new outfits, while game npcs, film and theatre are just fixed costumes

360-degree visibility - Must work from all angles (film = controlled camera)

Player control - Can't guarantee which angle/distance players see (theatre = fixed audience position)

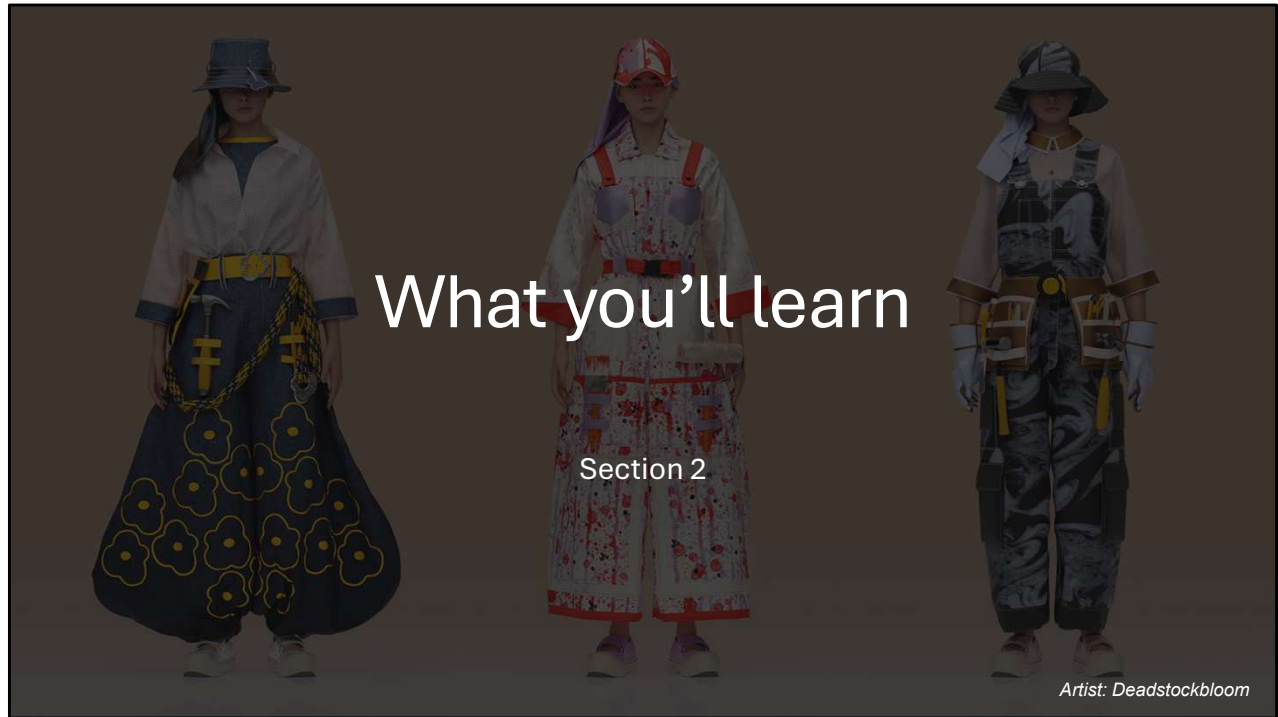
--Interactivity - Costume must work across animations, not just static poses

Performance constraints - Polygon budget, texture memory, real-time rendering

--Modularity - Often needs swappable parts for customization (film/theatre = fixed costume)

Extended viewing time - Players see costume for hours, not 2-hour performance

Reusability - Same base costume across cutscenes, gameplay, UI (film = specific to scene)



Alright that was a quick overview of some of the purposes of costuming, lets get into what youll learn in this guild

Guilds roadmap

- W1: **Foundations** (*today*)
- W2: **Medieval/Renaissance**
- W3: **Victorian/Industrial**
- W4: **Ancient & Cultural**
- W5: **Modern/Sci-Fi**
- W6: **Focus group**
- Standalone: **Hands-on material experience workshop**

Heres the planning of the coming guilds, the next 4 will be specific historical periods

And the 6th a focus group for my own master research where we will discuss and reflect on the sessions

There will also be a handson in person workshop where we will do different activities to experience fabrics in real life

Session structure

- Historical sessions follow same structure
- Same topics, different era
 - Period & game examples
 - Silhouette & key garments
 - Social hierarchy
 - Materials, textiles & dyes
 - Construction & details
 - Special topics

Costume principle guilds	Guild 2	Guild 3	Guild 4	Guild 5
Period & game examples	Medieval/ Renaissance 1200-1600s	Victorian/ Industrial 1800 - early 1900s	Ancient to folk / cultural Flexible	Modern to cyberpunk/sci-fi 1900s - future
Silhouette & key garments				
Social stratification				
Materials & textiles (and dyes)				
Construction & details				
Special topics (horse tack, creatures etc)	Horse tack & mounts	Corsetry deep dive	Creature adaptations	Asset bashing

Each historical session follow the same structure
Covering topics from silhouette to textiles and social classes

- Connecting real life to digital
- Fabric & behaviour
 - > Recognise materials
- Material > silhouette
- Draping & folds
- Patterning basics

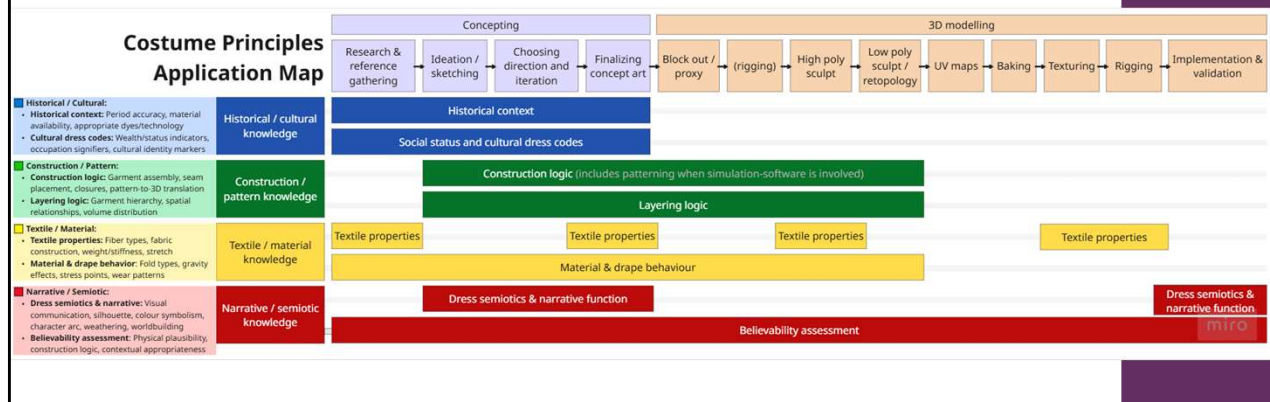


This will Give you better understanding of fabrics and help you start recognising them

And this will directly inform your digital work like sculpting, or cloth simulation
Which helps you create believable material textures for game characters

Where costume principles fit

Costume knowledge inform ALL stages of design process



This completes your quick course in costume literacy as costume knowledge informs all stages of the design process
I'll upload the slides to the team channel so you can always look at the images and info in your own pace afterwards



Lets get into the foundational concepts

Source background image:

https://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Joseph_Wright_of_Derby_-_Peter_Perez_Burdett_and_his_First_Wife_Hannah.JPG

Artist: Joseph Wright of Derby (1734–1797)

Title: Peter Perez Burdett and his First Wife Hannah

Object type painting

Visual language of costume

Silhouette = shape/outline

The most recognizable element



There are several different things that influence the visual language of the costume of a character

You all know about how important the silhouette is for a character

Here are three silhouettes

--First one is pyramid head from silent hill, apart from his head and sword, the butgers garb is the clothing item that is part of this silhouette

--And the second one is the main character of journey, where the whole outfit is the silhouette, we don't even know what they look like without it

Visual language of costume



Ghost of Tsushima



Witcher 3



Hogwarts Legacy

Materials = how it moves/behaves

The weight, drape, texture

Another important aspect is materials

How fabrics move and behave depend on the weight and drape of the fabric
And in combination with the texture, becomes recognisable and therefore
believable if chosen well

Visual language of costume



Horizon Forbidden West



The Last of Us

Construction = how it's made

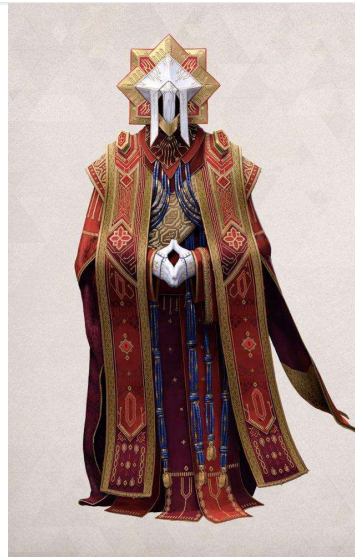
The seams, structure, fit

Then we have construction, this is about how it's made
Which can be seen through seams, structure and the fit of the garment which
can be seen in these two examples

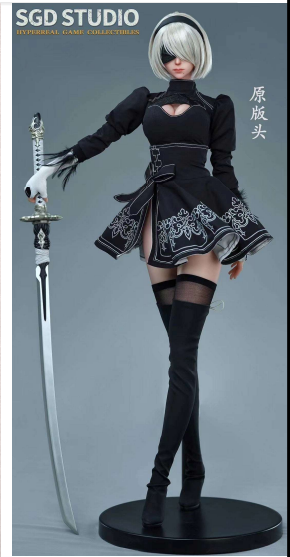
Visual language of costume



Forspoken



Horizon Forbidden West



Nier Automata

Details = embellishment, closures, trims

And finally details, this is everything from embellishments like jewellery to trims like embroidery and closures

All these visual language aspects inform the viewer of the characters place in the story and world

The Layering Approach

- Most period clothing = LAYERS
- Underlayers (foundation, structure)
- Mid layers (main garment)
- Outer layers (weather, status, decoration)

Why this matters: Affects how cloth behaves, how character moves



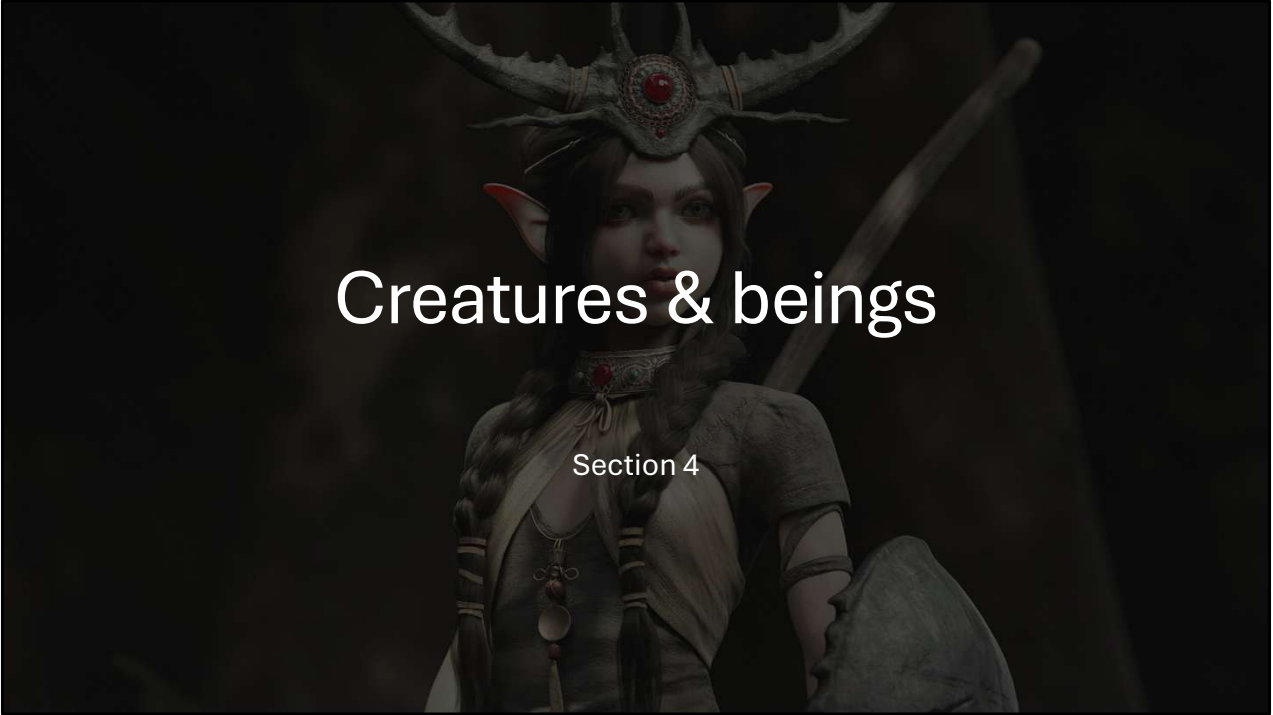
And because most character designs have roots in historical fashion in some shape or form,

Knowing that historical clothing uses layers, even if hidden matters

because: all these layers Affect how cloth behaves, how character moves

Layering the garments of your characters is inefficient for performance, but

knowing what would have gone underneath something, allows you to cheat it



Creatures & beings

Section 4

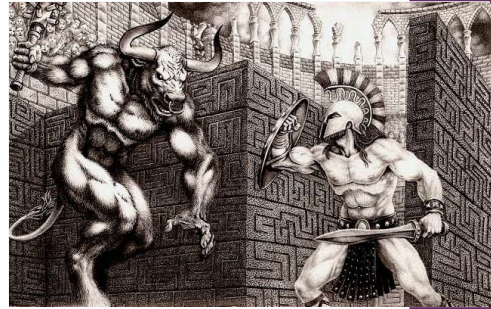
Alright the next topic is about creatures and beings

Creature Stereotypes Across Periods

Breaking vs. Following Expectations

- Following stereotypes = easy shorthand, players instantly understand
- Breaking stereotypes = requires explanation BUT can be more interesting

Both approaches valid - just need to know what you're doing



So theres a bunch of creatures and beings that the viewer would naturally expect in a certain time period or what they're wearing

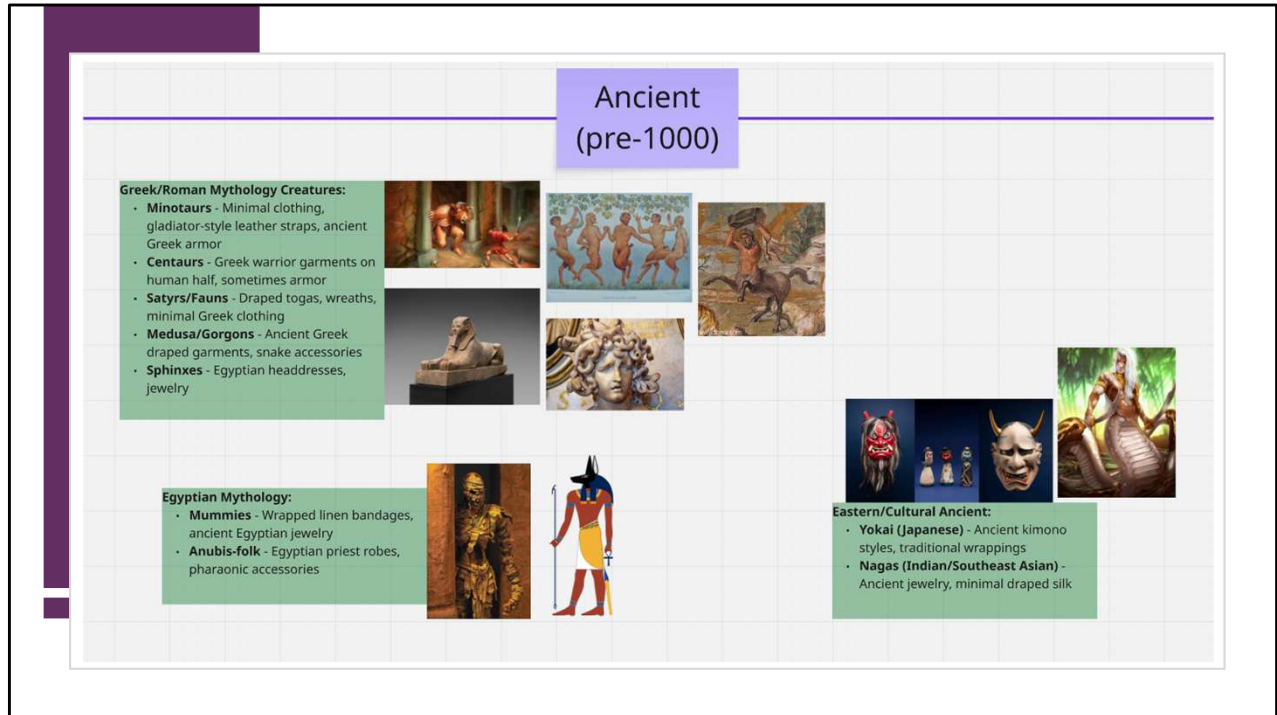
But Why do we expect these combinations? (often through Cultural coding in media)

For example: Minotaurs in Greek setting = makes sense immediately

Minotaurs in modern times = needs explanation (breaks expectations)

Cultural coding = instant viewer recognition and acceptance

Lets get into the historical periods and where each creature and being would be expected to show up in



Lets start with ancient history

Interestingly, but also logically, each being is often dressed in the garments of what humans were wearing in these periods

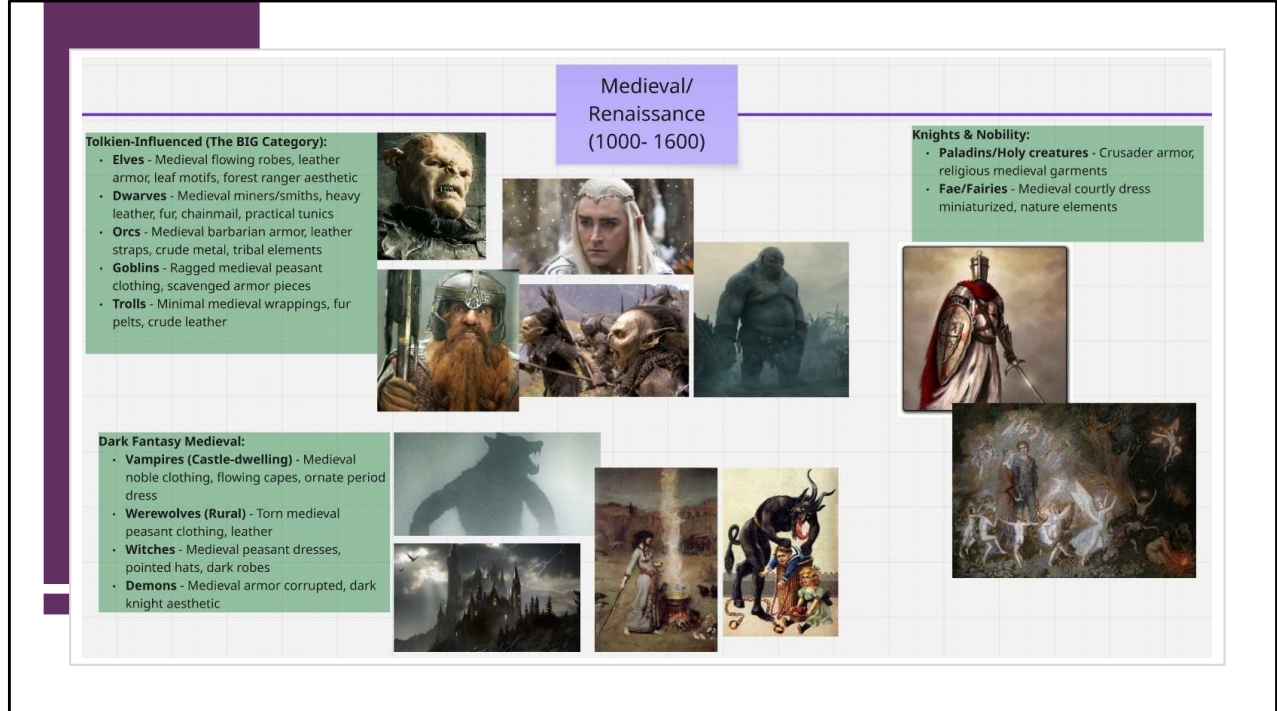
Here we have Greek and roman creatures scarcely dressed, mostly with straps or draped garments.

And Egyptian beings are inspired by the mummification process

The Anubis was the god of mummification, and its features reflect their beliefs again

And on the right is more eastern beings,

The garments or jewellery of these also reflect the humans from that time



Then medieval and renaissance

Tolkien influenced the beings in this period a lot with his books and movies.

He was also the first person to give a clear visual to what an Orc is supposed to look like

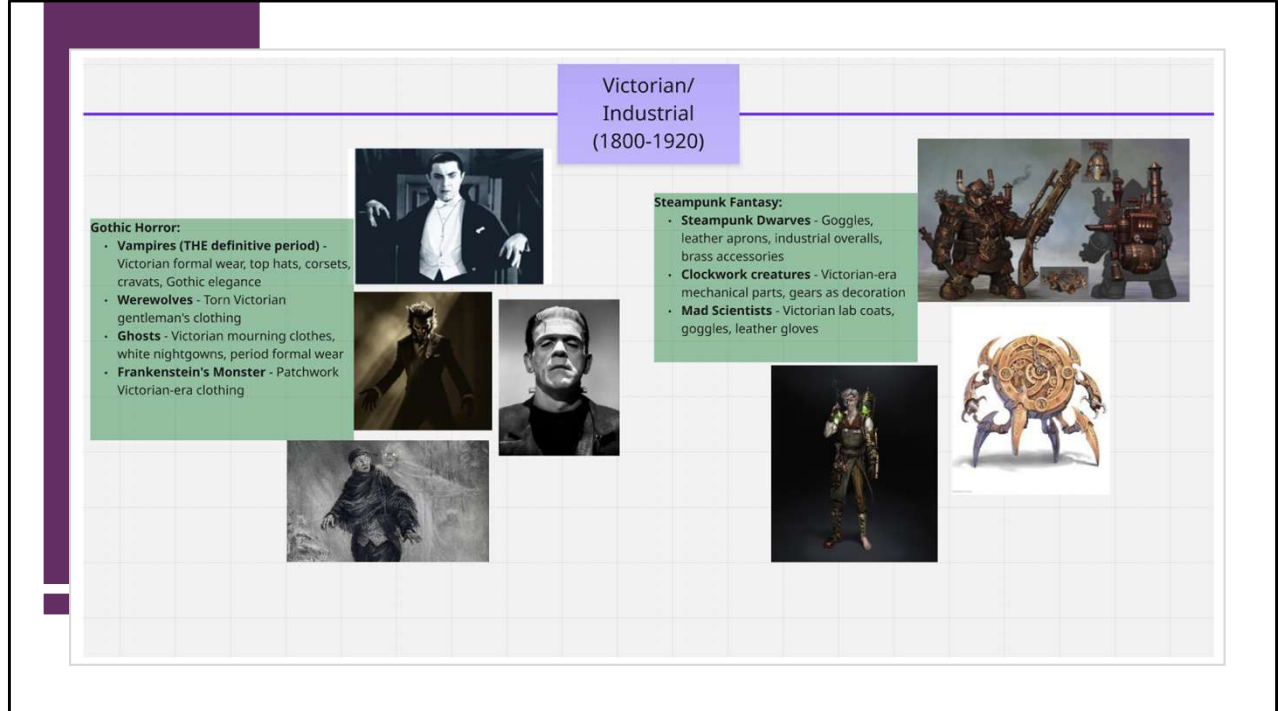
He drew inspiration from medieval European history

Some other beings like vampires, werewolves, witches and demons

Which come from folklore to explain death, disease and the unknown

They wear minimal clothing, or wear what the people wore in those periods, to fit in

And finally paladins and fairies, who, stereotypically, are exaggerations of knights and nobility



Victorian and industrial times came with steam or electric power, inventions and rapid urbanisation.

Novels like Dracula and Frankenstein explored these new themes.

These beings can be seen dressed in period wear, again, like what the people that time wore

There's also this other side of steampunk fantasy, where the idea of steampunk dwarves and clockwork creatures fit.

And exaggerates the theme of mad scientist.

It's not visualised but plague doctors with their masks, fit in between this era and the previous, around the 17th century

Modern (1920-2050)

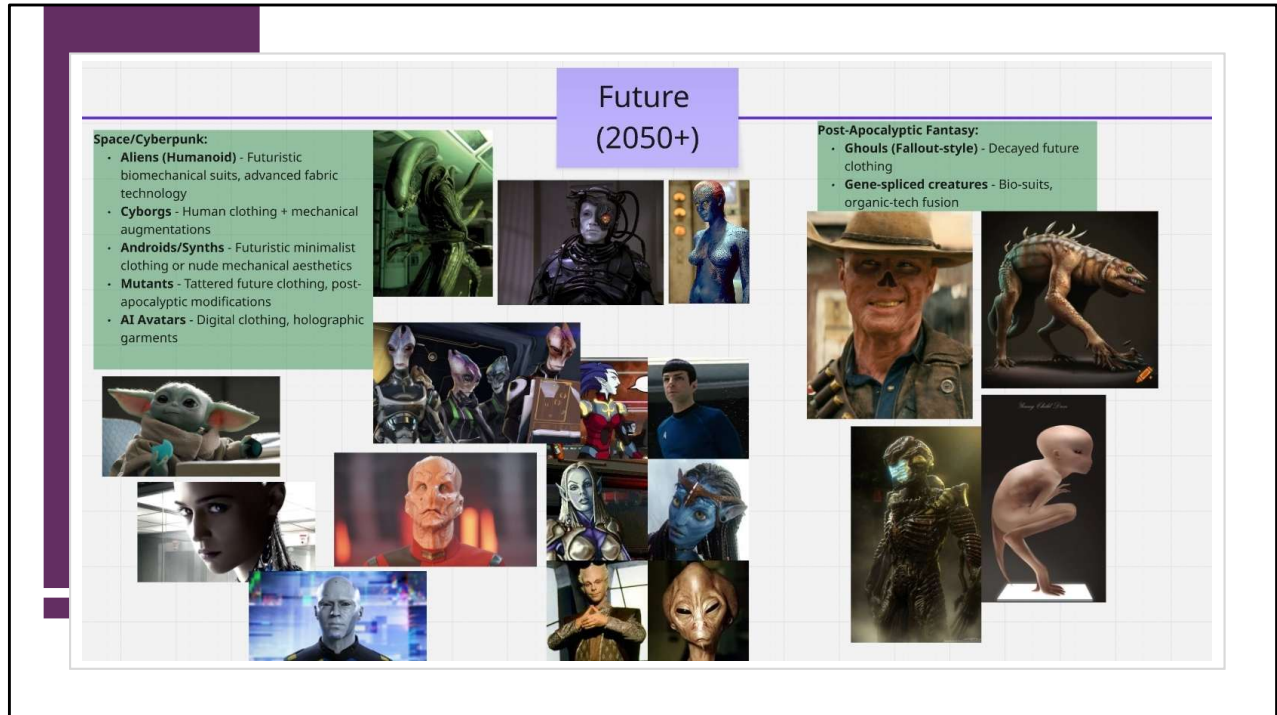
Urban Fantasy:

- **Modern Vampires** - Contemporary suits, leather jackets, modern Gothic fashion
- **Urban Werewolves** - Modern casual wear (that tears when transforming)
- **Demons (Urban)** - Business suits, modern streetwear, biker aesthetic
- **Angels (Urban)** - Modern formal wear, trench coats
- **Modern Witches** - Contemporary alternative fashion, modern robes
- **Zombies** - Whatever they died in (usually modern clothing)

Contemporary Supernatural:

- **Ghosts** - Modern clothing from their death era
- **Shapeshifters** - Adaptable modern clothing
- **Psychics/Espers** - Contemporary casual or mystical modern fusion

Zombies are new in this era, which came from haitian voodoo traditions and folklore which popularized around the 20th century



And lastly, the future

This contains a lot of speculative beings from aliens to cyborgs and mutants. Which includes ghouls, like fallout and other things like gene splice creatures or bio suits.

These are often based on predictions of how life might adapt to future changes or new worlds

I will cover some more of designing speculative fabrics in the guild about the future

Physical Adaptations

How do you dress a character with wings?
Horns? Tail? Multiple arms?



Patterns seen:

1. Minimalist approach
2. Separate layers
3. It's all armour approach

Bad examples



Good examples



With all these creatures and beings, comes different physiologies
So how can you dress a character with wings, horns, tails, multiple arms?

Bad examples

Skyrim argonian, human helmet on reptilian long nose, horns, all gets squished

Good examples

Final fantasy tail space in jacket (one of the only good ones of this game)

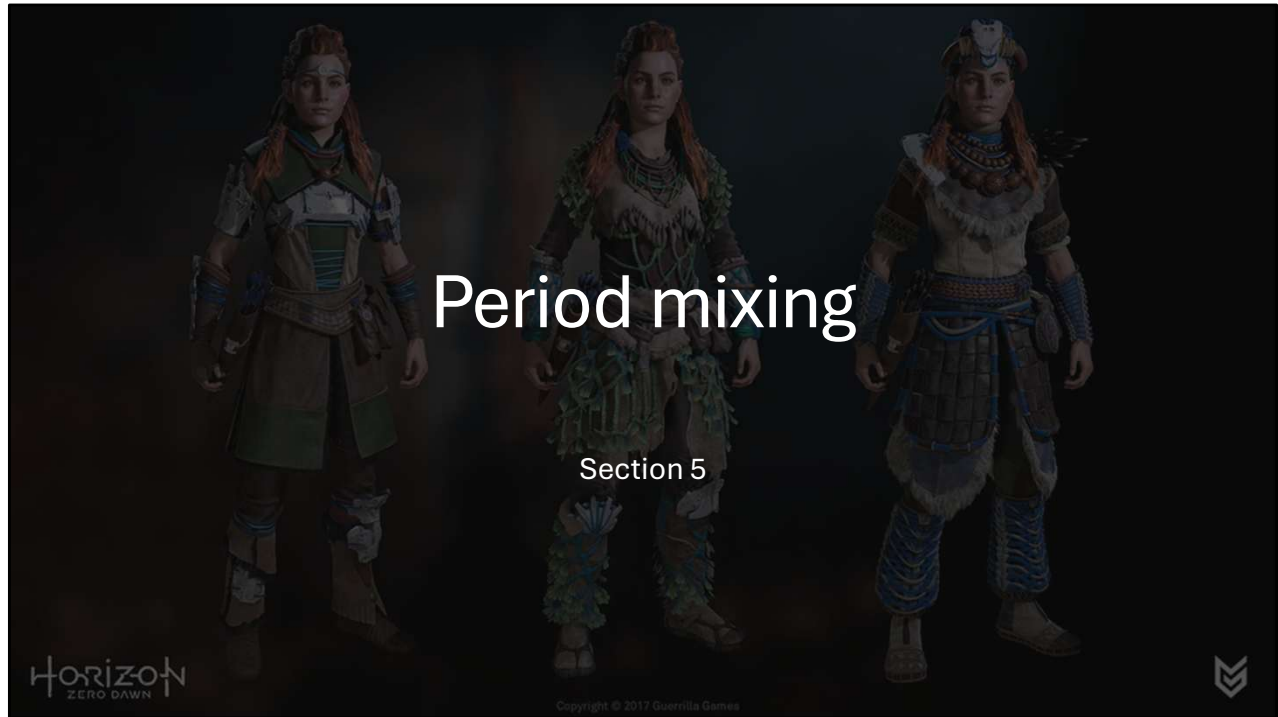
Deus Ex adam Jensen jacket, his cybernetic arms, sleeve design is accommodating for his arms

During the week 4 guild, I will go deeper into this but for now the Three Main "Solutions" Games Use:

The "Minimalist" Approach: keeps clothing simple and sleeveless, just avoiding the problem

The "Separate Layers" Approach: clipping issues that players learn to ignore

The "It's All Armor" Approach: Make wings appear to be part of the armour itself and not biological



Alright that was it for the short introduction to creatures and beings. Lets get into period mixing

Period Mixing in Games

- Quick Examples

Horizon Zero Dawn:

Tribal silhouettes + future materials (*ancient + sci-fi*)



A good example of period mixing is horizon

Horizon is a combination of tribes using ancient techniques with future materials because knowledge was lost

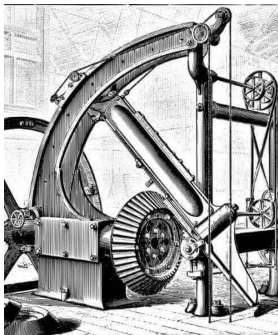
This is supported by the story and worldbuilding in the game and makes this mix believable

Period Mixing in Games

- Quick Examples

Dishonoured:

Victorian setting + industrial revolution by whale oil



+



=



Another example is dishonoured, which has a Victorian setting and they chose to change a historical detail

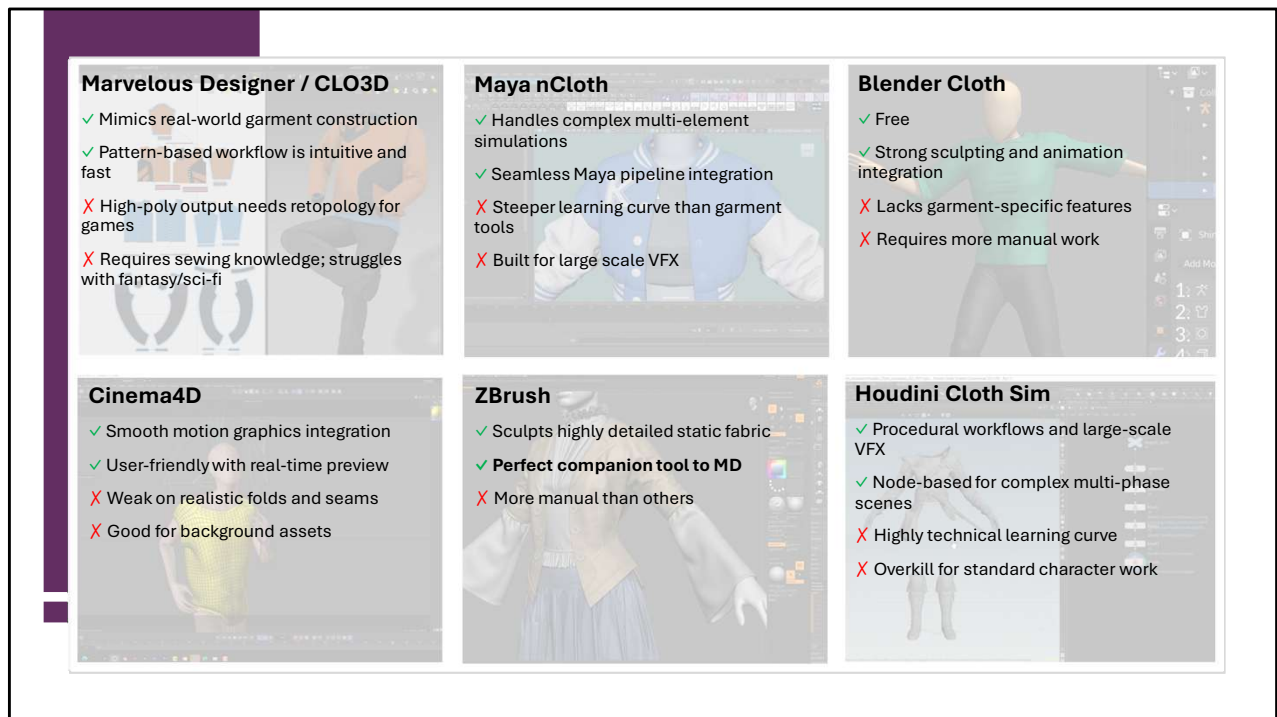
Now whale oil introduces the industrial revolution which makes it look different

Create original design

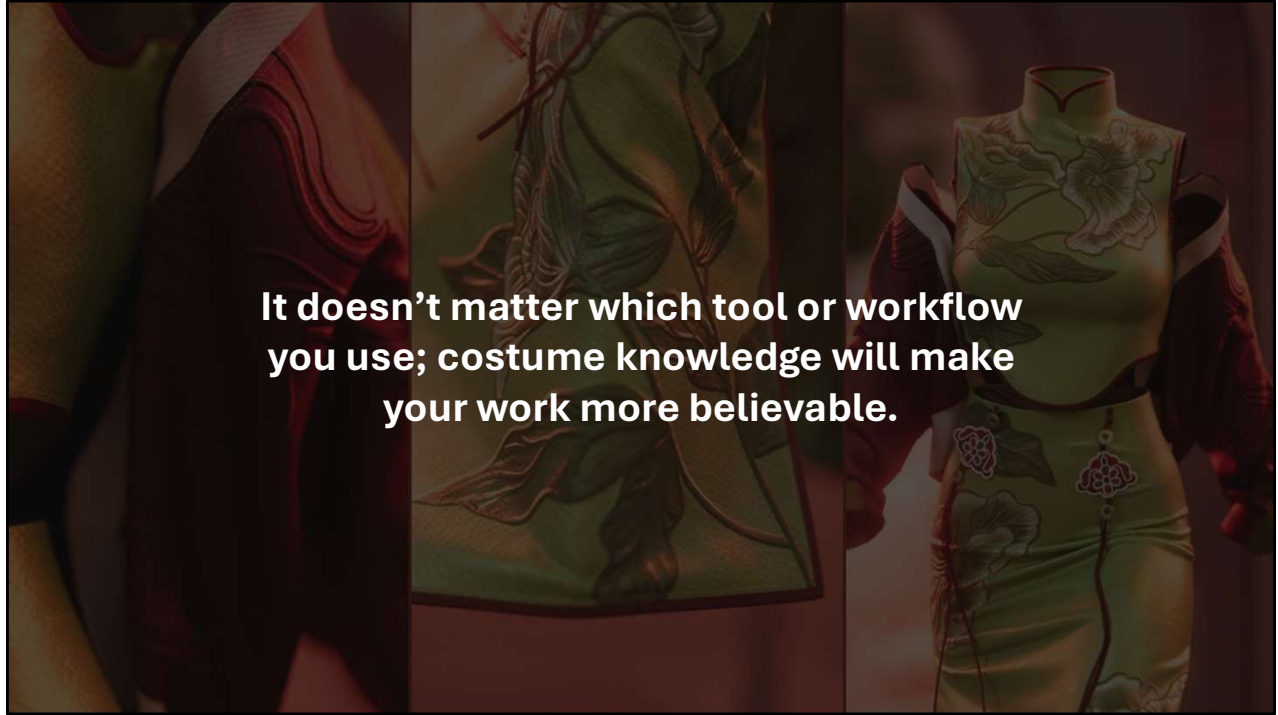
Games like **Dishonored**, **Bioshock**, and **Horizon** are masterclasses in period-mixing because they have **strong internal logic** for WHY the periods combine



Both of these games have strong internal logic for why periods are combining, this creates original design



There's many different programs to do this, each has their own pro's and cons. But my most important message is not about what program to design in, but --



That it



Wrap up Discussion & reflection

Section 7

Alright, I went through a lot of topics really fast as theres only time to cover them on the surface

Lets wrap up and have a short discussion and reflection

Quick recap

What we covered today:

- Different fashion vs costume
- Why costume matters
- Accuracy vs dramatization, narrative strengthening
- How costume for games is different than other media
- Visual language for costume design
- The period stereotypes for creatures and beings
- How other games mixed periods for original design
- Different tools to make game costumes



So we covered a bunch of topics today

My goal isn't to teach you everything there is to this topic

But to show you what exists so you can do further research yourself

Discussion & reflection

- Show/tell us what you've worked on before
- What do you know already?
- What will your focus of this block be?



Looking at your own work, what costume design principles did you use intentionally? Or unintentionally?

Looking at your own work, what materials did you use? Why those specific materials? Do those choices reflect the character's role, setting or personality? Does your character's costume reference any historical periods? If yes, which ones and why? If no, what informed your design choices instead?

If this character's costume were real, how would it be constructed? Where would the seams be? How would it fasten? What would need to be underneath?

What silhouette did you create for this character? Was this intentional? What does that shape communicate about them?

Looking at your character, what does their costume tell you about their social status, wealth, or position? What specific costume elements communicate this? Choose one costume element from your design (a specific garment, accessory, or detail). Why did you include it? What purpose does it serve beyond looking interesting?

Identify improvement points, skill level

Ask students about what they know before, what they learned now

Ask questions that can serve as pre guild and post guilds improvement check

Final question:

- Where would the hands-on workshop best work in your schedule? W4/5



Identify improvement points, skill level

Ask students about what they know before, what they learned now

Ask questions that can serve as pre guild and post guilds improvement check

Next guild:

Medieval & renaissance
Period: 1200 – 1600s

THE most used historical period in
video games

Same time same place 😊
Teams, 15:00-16:00



Most fantasy worlds default to medieval aesthetics because the visual language is instantly understandable